

***SUCH A
BAD GIRLFRIEND III***

THE SECRET BEHIND MY GOOL-GIRL ACT PART III

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Such a Bad Girlfriend III

The secret behind my good-girl act Part 3

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PMI

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I changed out of my work clothes, pulling on leggings and an oversized sweatshirt. The professional armor came off piece by piece, the silk blouse hung back in the closet, the pants folded over a hanger, the heels returned to their spot on the shoe rack. I caught my reflection in the mirror and paused, studying this version of myself. Casual. Comfortable. The girlfriend who stayed home and ordered Thai food and watched TV with her boyfriend.

In the bathroom, I washed my face, scrubbing away the makeup with more force than necessary. The deep red lipstick stained the white washcloth pink, and I watched the color bleed into the fabric, spreading like something wounded.

When I emerged, Owen was on the couch with his laptop open, already back to looking at data or code or whatever had consumed him before dinner. But he looked up when I appeared, closed the laptop, made space for me beside him.

"Thirty minutes," he said. "Come sit with me."

I curled up against his side, fitting myself into the familiar space, and he wrapped his arm around my shoulders. We sat in comfortable silence for a moment, and I could feel his heartbeat through his t-shirt, steady and reliable as everything else about him.

"Can I tell you something?" he said after a while.

My body tensed infinitesimally. "Of course."

"I was thinking today, during the presentation, about how lucky I am. Not just with the research going well, but... with you. With us." He turned slightly to look at me. "I know I don't say it enough, but you make everything better. Coming home to you, talking through my day with you, just... knowing you're here. It makes all the other stuff, the stress, the long hours, worth it."

The words should have made me feel something. Guilt, maybe. Shame. Some kind of emotional response proportional to what I'd been doing just hours before in a hotel room across town.

Instead, I felt that same clinical detachment, like I was observing his confession from a distance, noting it as interesting data but not feeling moved by it.

"You make me happy too," I said, and it wasn't entirely a lie. He did make me happy, in the way that stability and comfort and being adored made a person happy. It just wasn't the only thing that made me happy.

"Good," he said, kissing the top of my head. "That's all I want. For you to be happy."

If he only knew how happy I'd been attempting to be at one o'clock this afternoon.

The thought made me want to laugh, but I suppressed it, turning my face into his shoulder to hide whatever expression might have crossed it.

My phone buzzed in my pocket. I didn't need to check it to know it was probably Brady, still waiting for a response. The rain check question hanging there, unanswered.

"Your phone," Owen said unnecessarily.

"It can wait."

But I felt it buzz again a minute later. And then again.

Owen shifted slightly. "You sure you don't need to get that?"

"I'm sure." I pulled the phone out and silenced it without looking, then set it face-down on the coffee table, a pointed gesture of presence and attention.

Owen seemed satisfied with this. He picked up the remote and started scrolling through Netflix, looking for something we could half-watch while waiting for food. Some cooking competition show started playing, and we both pretended to pay attention while actually doing nothing of the sort.

My mind kept drifting back to the hotel room. To Brady's frustration. To the way the whole thing had fallen apart. I was already planning the next time, how to do it better, how to avoid the interruptions, how to maintain control. Maybe I needed to be more explicit about the rules. No phones at all. A complete blackout window where nothing from the outside world could intrude.

Or maybe I needed someone different entirely. Someone who didn't text afterward, who didn't want rain checks or relationship-adjacent intimacy. Someone who understood that this was purely transactional.

The thought excited me in a way that probably said something unflattering about my character.

The food arrived, and Owen got up to answer the door, returning with the familiar paper bag that smelled like lemongrass and chili oil. We ate at the coffee table, the TV still playing its mindless background noise, passing containers back and forth.

"This was a good idea," I said, and meant it. The food was good. The company was easy. This version of my life was perfectly acceptable.

It just wasn't ... enough.

After dinner, Owen suggested a movie, something we'd been meaning to watch for weeks. I agreed, and we settled in for the long haul, his arm around me, my head on his shoulder, the picture of domestic contentment.

Halfway through, my phone lit up on the coffee table. I could see Brady's name on the screen even from this distance, even without picking it up.

Owen noticed. "You're popular tonight."

"Just work stuff probably," I said without looking. "I'll deal with it tomorrow."

But I watched the screen glow and then fade to black, and felt the pull of it. The unanswered message. The unfinished business. The loose thread that needed to be tied off or pulled or cut completely.

When the movie ended, Owen stretched and yawned, checking his watch. "I should probably get some sleep. Early meeting tomorrow."

"Yeah, me too."

We went through our nighttime routine, teeth brushing, face washing, the comfortable choreography of a couple who'd shared a bathroom for two years. In bed, Owen pulled me close and kissed me goodnight, his hand resting on my hip in a way that suggested he might want more, but when I didn't reciprocate the signal, he didn't push.

"Night, Nat. Love you."

"Love you too."

He fell asleep within minutes, his breathing evening out into the deep rhythm of unconsciousness. I lay awake beside him in the dark, staring at nothing, my mind racing through scenarios and possibilities and plans.

Eventually, I slipped out of bed, careful not to wake Owen. He didn't stir, just shifted slightly and kept sleeping, his face peaceful in the dim light from the window. I grabbed my phone from the nightstand and padded quietly to the bathroom, closing the door before turning on the light.

The brightness was harsh after the darkness. I squinted at my reflection, bare-faced, hair messy, wearing one of Owen's old t-shirts. The most honest

version of myself, supposedly, though even now I was aware of how I looked, cataloging the dark circles under my eyes, the slight puffiness.

I opened my messages. Four from Brady over the course of the evening:

Hey. Sorry about today. Rain check?

I know you're probably busy

Just want to make sure we're cool

Natalie?

The progression from casual to concerned was almost textbook. I could see his confidence eroding with each unanswered message, the doubt creeping in. Good. Let him wonder. Let him feel uncertain for once.

I typed: *We're fine. Today was just off. Next week?*

The response came within seconds, which meant he'd been waiting, phone probably in his hand, obsessively checking.

Brady: *Yes. Definitely. Tuesday?*

Me: *Tuesday works. Same time*

Brady: *Can't wait. I'll make it up to you*

I almost laughed at that. Make it up to me. Like he owed me something. Like this was a relationship with debts and credits and reciprocal obligations.

Me: *Just be ready to focus. No distractions*

Brady: *Promise. It'll be just us*

I deleted the conversation thread, all of it, back to the beginning, and then blocked his number. Waited five seconds. Unblocked it. The messages stayed deleted. Clean slate, no evidence, just the way I liked it.

Back in the bedroom, I slid under the covers next to Owen. He made a small sound and reached for me in his sleep, pulling me against him. His body was warm, familiar, safe. I closed my eyes and tried to match my breathing to his, willing myself toward sleep.

But my mind wouldn't stop moving. It kept circling back to Brady, to the hotel room, to the failure of it. And underneath that, something else was nagging at me. Something about the way Owen had looked at me tonight when he'd said that thing about being lucky. Really looked at me, like he was trying to see something beneath the surface.

Had he noticed something? Some detail I'd missed, some crack in the fourth wall?

No. Impossible. I was too careful. I'd spent two years being careful, building this parallel life with meticulous attention to detail. Owen saw

what I wanted him to see, believed what I needed him to believe.

Still, the unease persisted, a low-level hum of anxiety that kept me awake even as exhaustion pulled at me.

I must have eventually dozed because I woke to Owen's alarm, the room gray with early morning light. He silenced it quickly and turned to kiss my forehead.

"Morning," he whispered. "Go back to sleep. You don't have to be up yet."

I mumbled something and closed my eyes, listening to him move around the room getting ready. The shower running. The closet opening and closing. The smell of coffee drifting in from the kitchen. All the familiar sounds of our morning routine.

When the front door closed behind him, I opened my eyes and stared at the ceiling. That water stain again. I really should mention it to the landlord.

My phone showed 6:47 AM. Too early to be properly awake, but I knew I wouldn't fall back asleep now. I got up and made myself coffee, scrolling through Instagram while the machine hissed and dripped.

Jessica had posted a story, some inspirational quote about authenticity and being true to yourself. I almost laughed. Authenticity. As if anyone was truly authentic, as if we weren't all just performing versions of ourselves depending on the audience.

I responded to her message from yesterday about drinks: *Tuesday at 7 still works!*

The exclamation point was important. It conveyed enthusiasm, normalcy, the kind of casual friendliness that suggested everything in my life was exactly as it appeared to be.

At the office, Miranda caught me before I'd even reached my desk. "Conference room in ten. Whole creative team. I've got news."

She looked excited, which either meant very good news or very bad news. With Miranda, it was hard to tell until she said it outright.

The conference room filled up, me, three other designers, two copywriters, David from account management. Miranda stood at the head of the table with her laptop open, looking like she was about to announce something significant.

"So," she said, "I got a call from the Peterson people yesterday afternoon. They've been impressed with our work on the boutique hotel campaign, and they want us to pitch for their entire brand refresh. This is big. Like, career-

defining big. Budget is seven figures, timeline is aggressive, and they specifically asked for Natalie to lead."

Everyone turned to look at me. I felt a spike of genuine pleasure, pride, maybe, or at least its close cousin. Recognition. Validation that I was good at what I did, that my talent was being seen and valued.

"That's amazing," I said, smiling. "I'm honored they thought of me."

"You earned it. That boutique campaign was stellar." Miranda clicked to the next slide. "Here's the catch: they want the pitch in three weeks. Which means we're about to enter crunch time. Late nights, weekend work, all hands on deck. Everyone good with that?"

Nods around the table. Murmurs of agreement.

I calculated quickly. Three weeks of intensified work schedule. More legitimate reasons to be late, to be unavailable, to have my time accounted for in ways that Owen would understand and accept.

More cover for whatever else I wanted to do.

"I'm in," I said. "Let's do this."

The Peterson project consumed the next week. Miranda wasn't exaggerating about the intensity. By Wednesday, we were all staying past eight every night, the office littered with empty coffee cups and takeout containers. I was actually doing the work, actually earning the late nights, which felt strange in its legitimacy.

Owen was understanding, of course. "I get it," he'd said when I texted him Tuesday night that I wouldn't be home until nine. "Big opportunity. I'm proud of you. Want me to save you some dinner?"

He'd had pasta waiting when I got home, still warm in the pot, and had sat with me while I ate even though he'd already finished his own meal hours ago. Listening to me talk about the project, asking thoughtful questions, being supportive in that unwavering way of his.

I'd almost felt guilty.

Tuesday with Brady had been cancelled, I'd texted him Monday night with genuine regret about the work situation, and he'd been disappointed but understanding. "Next week then," he'd written. "I miss you."

The "I miss you" had irritated me. Too much feeling. Too much implication of connection beyond the physical. But I'd let it go, just responded with a noncommittal "Soon." and left it at that.

By Thursday afternoon, I was actually tired in a real way, not a pretended way. My eyes felt gritty from staring at screens. My shoulders ached from

hunching over my desk. When Miranda suggested we all take Friday afternoon off to recharge before the weekend push, I felt genuine relief.

I texted Owen: *Got Friday afternoon off. Want to do something? Just us?*

His response was immediate: *Yes! I can leave early too. Maybe that hiking trail you've been wanting to try?*

I had mentioned a hiking trail once, months ago, in passing. The fact that he remembered made something twist in my chest.

Me: *Perfect. It's a date*

Owen: *Can't wait*

Friday morning, I actually found myself looking forward to it. The normalcy of it, the simplicity. No acting required, no logistics to manage, no secrets to keep track of. Just a hike with my boyfriend on a beautiful day.

I dressed in leggings and a fitted tank top, pulled my hair into a high ponytail, packed water bottles and granola bars into a small backpack. Owen picked me up from the office at one, already changed into athletic wear, grinning at me through the car window.

"Adventure time," he said as I climbed in.

The trail was forty minutes outside the city, winding up into hills that overlooked the valley. It was moderately challenging, steep enough to get our heart rates up but not so difficult that we couldn't talk. Owen held my hand on the narrow parts, pointed out birds he recognized, made terrible jokes about rock formations.

I let myself be present for it. Actually present, not performing presence. Let myself laugh at his jokes, squeeze his hand when the trail got steep, stop to admire the view when we reached a clearing.

"This is nice," I said, catching my breath, looking out at the city spread below us, hazy in the afternoon heat.

"Yeah?" Owen came up behind me, wrapping his arms around my waist, resting his chin on my shoulder. "I feel like we haven't done this in a while. Just... hung out. No pressure, no schedules."

"I know. Work's been insane."

"For both of us." He was quiet for a moment, then said, "Can I ask you something?"

That familiar tension crept back into my shoulders. "Sure."

"Are you happy? Like, really happy. Not just with work or the apartment or whatever. But with us? With me?"

I turned in his arms to face him, studying his expression. He looked genuinely uncertain, vulnerable in a way I didn't often see from him. His confidence was usually so quiet and complete, but right now he looked like someone who genuinely didn't know the answer to his question.

"Why would you ask that?" I said carefully.

"I don't know. You just seem... distant sometimes. Like you're here but not really here." He pushed his glasses up his nose, a nervous gesture. "And I know you're stressed with work, and I don't want to add pressure, but I just... I want to make sure we're okay."

This was dangerous territory. I could feel it, the way the conversation was edging toward something that could unravel if I wasn't careful.

"We're okay," I said, putting my hands on his chest, looking directly into his eyes. "I'm sorry if I've seemed distant. The Peterson thing has just been consuming my brain. But you and me? We're good. We're really good."

"You'd tell me if something was wrong, right? If you were unhappy or if I was doing something that bothered you?"

"Of course I would."

The lie came so easily, so naturally. And the worst part was that he believed me immediately, his expression relaxing, relief flooding his features.

"Okay. Good. I just needed to hear it." He pulled me closer, kissing me softly. "I love you so much, Nat. Sometimes I worry that you don't really know how much."

"I know," I said against his lips. "I love you too."

We stood there for a while, holding each other, the city spread out below us like a map of all the places we'd been and might go. And I felt something in that moment, not guilt exactly, but an awareness. An awareness that what I was doing was working because of how good he was. How trusting. How willing to believe the best of me.

A worse person would have felt bad about that.

I just filed it away as useful information.

We hiked back down as the sun started its descent, golden light filtering through the trees, casting long shadows across the trail. Owen was in high spirits, energized by our conversation, by my reassurance. He talked about plans for the summer, places we could visit, things we could do together.

I made agreeable sounds, nodded at the right moments, squeezed his hand when he got particularly enthusiastic about some camping trip he

wanted to take.

Back at the apartment, Owen suggested we shower together. "To save water," he said with a grin that suggested water conservation wasn't really his primary motivation.

I agreed, and we undressed in the bathroom, steam filling the small space as the water heated. Under the spray, Owen was gentle and thorough, washing my hair with careful fingers, soaping my back, his hands sliding over my skin with familiar ease.

He pressed me against the tile wall, kissing me deeply, and I felt him hard against my thigh. His hand slid between my legs, and I made the appropriate sounds, let my head fall back against the wall, played the part of the girlfriend being ravished in the shower.

We had sex right there, Owen lifting me slightly, my legs wrapped around his waist, the water cascading over both of us. It was good, he was attentive, made sure I was ready, checked in with his eyes to see if the angle was right. When he came, he gasped my name like it meant something sacred.

After, we dried off and collapsed on the bed, both of us drowsy and satisfied. Owen fell asleep within minutes, his arm draped across my stomach, his breathing deep and even.

I lay there awake, staring at the ceiling, thinking about Brady. About how different it felt with him, rougher, more selfish, more real in some perverse way. Owen made love to me. Brady fucked me. And I wanted both, needed both, couldn't choose between them because they served different purposes in the architecture of who I was.

My phone buzzed on the nightstand. I reached for it carefully, not wanting to wake Owen.

Brady: *Thinking about you*

Brady: *When can I see you again?*

I should have felt annoyed at the intrusion, at his neediness. Instead, I felt a spike of interest. The hike with Owen had been nice. The shower sex had been pleasant. But nice and pleasant weren't enough. They never had been.

I slipped out of bed and went to the living room, closing the bedroom door softly behind me. The apartment was dark except for the ambient city light through the windows. I curled up on the couch and opened my messages.

Me: *Tuesday. 1pm. Different hotel this time*

Brady: *Where?*

I opened a browser and searched for boutique hotels, something with personality, something that felt more dangerous than the Morrison. I found one called The Gramercy, known for its discretion, its intimate rooms, its reputation as a place where married executives took their mistresses.

Perfect.

Me: *The Gramercy. I'll text you the room number*

Brady: *Fancy. You spoiling me?*

Me: *Maybe. Or maybe I just want somewhere we won't be interrupted*

Brady: *I like the sound of that*

Brady: *What are you wearing right now?*

The question was obvious, predictable, but it still sent a small thrill through me. I glanced toward the bedroom door, where Owen slept peacefully, trusting completely.

Me: *Nothing. Just got out of the shower*

Brady: *Fuck. You're killing me*

Brady: *Touch yourself. Tell me what it feels like*

I should have shut this down. Should have said goodnight, put the phone away, gone back to bed with my boyfriend. Instead, I felt my hand slide down my stomach, between my legs, finding myself still slightly sensitive from Owen.

Me: *Wet. Thinking about Tuesday*

Brady: *What do you want me to do to you?*

I typed with one hand, the other moving in slow circles, my breathing getting shorter. The depravity of it wasn't lost on me, getting myself off while texting my side piece, ten feet away from where my boyfriend slept, still warm from having sex with him an hour ago.

It should have disgusted me. Instead, it made everything more intense.

Me: *Everything. I want you to do everything*

Brady: *I'm going to make you scream. You won't be able to walk when I'm done with you*

Me: *Promises promises*

Brady: *I mean it. Tuesday you're mine. All mine*

The possessiveness should have irritated me, but in this moment, it worked. I let myself imagine it, Brady in some expensive hotel room, me walking in wearing something designed to destroy him, the afternoon

stretching out with no interruptions, no phones, nothing but the two of us and everything we could do to each other.

My breathing was getting ragged now, my fingers moving faster, and I bit my lip to keep quiet.

Me: *I'm close*

Brady: *Come for me. Tell me when you do*

I did, the orgasm rolling through me sharp and quick, and I had to press my face into the couch cushion to muffle the sound. When it subsided, I lay there for a moment, my heart pounding, feeling the wrongness of what I'd just done settle over me like a second skin.

Me: *Done. That was good*

Brady: *Wish I could have watched*

Brady: *Tuesday can't come fast enough*

Me: *Goodnight Brady*

I deleted the conversation thread again, every message erased like it had never happened, and sat in the dark living room trying to parse what I was feeling. Not guilt. Not shame. Something closer to satisfaction. The satisfaction of having successfully navigated multiple realities at once, the good girlfriend, the passionate lover, the woman who could compartmentalize so completely that she could come from her boyfriend and her affair partner within an hour of each other and feel nothing but pleased with her own efficiency.

I went back to the bedroom. Owen had rolled over but was still deeply asleep, one arm stretched across my side of the bed like he'd been reaching for me. I slid under the covers and into his arms, and he made a contented sound and pulled me closer without waking.

"Love you," he mumbled, mostly asleep.

"Love you too," I whispered back.

And the terrible truth was, I did love him. Just not enough to stop.

The weekend passed in domestic contentment. Owen and I went to the farmer's market Sunday morning, bought overpriced heirloom tomatoes and fresh bread, came home and made lunch together. His parents' dinner was pleasant, his mother asked about my work without listening to me answer, her with a tiny grin I couldn't read, his father talked about a book he was reading, and I played the role of devoted girlfriend with practiced ease.

Monday brought me back to the Peterson project with renewed focus. The pitch was taking shape, the creative concepts solidifying, and I was

genuinely proud of what we were building. Miranda kept praising my leadership, my vision, my ability to pull the team together.

"You're really stepping up," she said Monday afternoon, reviewing my latest mockups. "This is associate creative director level work, Natalie. I'm serious."

The validation felt good. Real. A reminder that I was more than just my secrets, that I had actual talent, actual value beyond my ability to deceive.

But Tuesday was coming.

I'd booked The Gramercy at nearly three hundred dollars. More than I should spend, but I'd justified it as treating myself. A reward for the hard work on Peterson. Owen would never see the credit card statement anyway.

Tuesday morning, I dressed with particular care. A black wrap dress that looked professional but untied with a single pull. Matching black lingerie underneath, lace and silk, expensive, the kind that made me feel powerful. I did my makeup darker than usual, more dramatic. When I looked in the mirror, I saw someone who could destroy a man if she wanted to.

Owen was already gone, early lab meeting, but he'd left a note on the kitchen counter: "Good luck with work today! Love you."

I photographed the note and posted it to my Instagram story with the caption "Best human." and watched the reactions roll in. Heart emojis from friends. "So cute!" from acquaintances. The illusion of a perfect relationship, curated for public consumption.

At the office, I worked until noon, actually worked, getting through a mountain of revisions and client feedback. Then I told Miranda I had a dentist appointment.

"At one?" she said, looking skeptical.

"Only time they could fit me in. Emergency filling. I'll be back by three."

The lie was so smooth, so practiced, that it landed without question. "Feel better," Miranda said, already turning back to her screen.

The Gramercy was in a quieter part of downtown, a converted historic building with an unmarked entrance that you'd miss if you didn't know to look for it. Inside, the lobby was all dark wood and velvet furniture, intimate lighting, the kind of place that promised discretion.

The clerk at the desk was a woman in her fifties with impeccable makeup and an expression that suggested she'd seen everything and judged nothing.

"Reservation for Chen," I said.

She checked her computer. "Room 304. Third floor. Enjoy your stay."

No smile, no small talk, just the key card across the marble counter. Professional indifference that I appreciated.

Room 304 was at the end of a narrow hallway, the carpet thick enough to muffle footsteps. I unlocked the door and stepped inside.

The room was smaller than the Morrison but more luxurious. A four-poster bed with burgundy linens, exposed brick walls, a chaise lounge by the window, heavy curtains that could block out the world completely. The bathroom had a clawfoot tub and rain shower, thick towels stacked on heated racks.

I set my purse on the dresser and checked my reflection in the full-length mirror. The wrap dress clung to my curves perfectly. My hair fell in loose waves over my shoulders. My lipstick was a deep wine color that made my lips look fuller, more dramatic.

I looked like sex. Deliberate, calculated sex.

My phone showed 12:54. I texted Brady: *Room 304*

Then I did something I'd never done before. I set my phone to Do Not Disturb. Complete silence. No calls, no texts, no notifications from Owen or work or anyone else. For the next two hours, I was erasing myself from my regular life entirely.

The power of it made my pulse quicken.

I poured myself water from the complimentary bottles on the dresser and stood by the window, looking out at the street below. A couple walked past hand-in-hand. A businessman checked his phone while waiting for a light. Normal people living normal lives, completely unaware of what was happening three floors above them.

The knock I was awaiting came at the door, soft and tentative.

I took my time crossing the room, letting him wait, building the anticipation. When I opened it, Brady stood there in dark jeans and a black henley, his gym bag over his shoulder like always, looking at me like he was starving and I was his meal.

"Jesus Christ," he breathed.

I stepped back to let him in, and he dropped his bag immediately, reaching for me. His hands found my waist, my face, pulling me into a kiss that was hungry and demanding. I kissed him back with equal intensity, my fingers pushing through his hair, pulling him closer.

He pushed toward the bed, his hands already working at the tie of my wrap dress, and I let him, feeling the fabric loosen and fall open. His breath

caught when he saw the lingerie underneath.

"You wore this for me," he said, and it wasn't a question.

"I wore this for me," I corrected, but I was smiling.

His hands slid the dress off my shoulders, letting it pool at my feet, and he just looked at me for a long moment, standing there in black lace and heels, backlit by the window, and I could see in his face that he was completely, utterly lost.

"On the bed," I said, my voice low and commanding.

Something flickered in his expression, surprise, maybe, or arousal, but he complied, sitting on the edge of the mattress, looking up at me.

I stepped closer, close enough that I was standing between his knees, and tilted his chin up with one finger.

"We're going to do this differently today," I said, looking down at him. "No rushing. No distractions. Just exactly what I want, when I want it."

Brady nodded, his eyes dark with want, his hands moving to my hips. But I stepped back, just out of reach.

"I didn't say you could touch me yet."

His hands dropped immediately, and I saw his jaw tighten. Good. I wanted him uncertain, off-balance, waiting for permission.

I walked slowly around the bed, letting him watch me, letting the anticipation build. The room was quiet except for our breathing and the muffled sounds of the city outside. I pulled the curtains closed, reducing the light to a warm amber glow from the bedside lamps.

When I came back to stand in front of him, I could see the tension in his shoulders, the way his hands were gripping the edge of the mattress to keep from reaching for me.

"Take off your shirt," I said.

He complied quickly, pulling the henley over his head and tossing it aside. His chest was exactly as I remembered, defined, athletic, the body of someone who spent serious time in the gym. I let my fingers trail across his collarbone, down his sternum, feeling his muscles tense under my touch.

"Pants too."

He stood and undid his belt, the leather sliding through the loops with a soft whisper. Unbuttoned his jeans, pushed them down along with his boxers, and stepped out of them. He was already hard, had probably been hard since he walked in the door.

"Lie back," I instructed.

He did, settling against the pillows, and I climbed onto the bed, straddling his thighs but not touching him where he wanted to be touched. Instead, I leaned forward and kissed him slowly, thoroughly, my hands braced on either side of his head. His hands came up to my waist, and this time I allowed it, let him hold me while I controlled the kiss.

My hair fell around our faces like a curtain, blocking out everything else. I could taste him, mint, coffee, want, and feel the heat of his body beneath me. When I pulled back, his pupils were blown wide, his breathing ragged.

I sat up and reached behind me to unhook my bra, holding his gaze while I let it fall away. His eyes dropped immediately to my breasts, and I watched him swallow hard.

"You can touch," I said. "But only where I tell you."

His hands moved to cup my breasts, his thumbs brushing over my nipples, and I let my head fall back slightly, arching into his touch. It felt good, the calluses on his palms, the confident way he handled me, like he knew exactly what he was doing.

I rocked my hips forward, still wearing the lace underwear, grinding against him through the thin fabric. He groaned, his hands tightening on my breasts, and I did it again, slower this time, watching his face contort with pleasure and frustration.

"Natalie," he breathed. "Please."

"Please what?"

"I need ..." He couldn't finish the sentence, his hips bucking up involuntarily.

I reached down between us and pushed my underwear to the side, not taking them off, just creating access. Then I positioned myself above him and sank down slowly, inch by inch, watching his face the entire time.

His eyes squeezed shut, his mouth falling open, and I felt him stretch me, fill me, exactly the way I'd been thinking about since Thursday. When I was fully seated, I paused, letting us both adjust to the sensation.

"Look at me," I said.

His eyes opened, glassy and unfocused, and I started to move. Slow at first, rolling my hips in a rhythm that was more for me than for him, chasing my own pleasure. His hands gripped my waist, trying to guide me faster, harder, but I kept my own pace.

The four-poster bed creaked softly beneath us. The burgundy linens were already getting tangled from our movement. I braced my hands on his chest

and rode him with deliberate slowness, feeling every sensation, the drag of him inside me, the pressure against my clit each time I ground forward, the building heat low in my belly.

"God, you're perfect," Brady gasped, and his hands slid up to my breasts again, cupping them, thumbs circling my nipples.

I leaned forward and kissed him, deep and consuming, and changed the angle. This position hit differently, deeper, and I made a sound against his mouth that was pure pleasure.

My phone was face-down on the dresser, silenced, invisible. Owen was at the lab, probably knee-deep in data, completely unaware. The office thought I was at the dentist. No one knew where I really was or what I was really doing.

The freedom of it was intoxicating.

I sat up again and increased my pace, my hands splayed across Brady's abdomen for leverage. He was getting close, I could tell from the way his breathing had changed, the way his fingers were digging into my hips, the desperate sounds he was making.

But I wasn't there yet, and I wasn't about to let him finish before me.

I stopped moving entirely, staying perfectly still with him buried inside me, and watched frustration flash across his face.

"Not yet," I said.

"Natalie, I can't, "

"Yes, you can." I clenched around him deliberately, and he made a strangled sound. "You'll wait for me."

I started moving again, but this time I reached down to touch myself, my fingers finding my clit, working in quick circles. Brady watched, his eyes fixed on where we were joined, where my hand was moving, and I could see it was killing him to hold back.

"That's so fucking hot," he managed.

I felt the pressure building, that tightening coil of sensation that meant I was getting close. My fingers moved faster, and I rode him harder now, chasing it, everything focused down to this singular purpose.

"Touch my breasts," I told him, and his hands came up immediately, palming them, squeezing, his thumbs working my nipples in a way that sent electricity straight through me.

The orgasm hit suddenly, rolling through me in waves, and I cried out, not caring who might hear through the walls, not caring about anything

except the sensation flooding my body. I felt myself clench around him, pulsing, and heard Brady groan beneath me.

"Now," I gasped. "Come now."

His hips bucked up hard, and I felt him let go, felt him finish inside me with a sound that was half-relief, half-desperation. I kept moving through it, drawing it out, until he was shuddering beneath me, completely spent.

I collapsed forward onto his chest, both of us breathing hard, slick with sweat. His arms came around me automatically, holding me close, and for a moment we just lay there in the aftermath.

My phone buzzed on the dresser, once, twice, three times in rapid succession. Even on Do Not Disturb, emergency calls from favorites could break through.

Brady felt me tense. "You need to check that?"

"No," I said firmly, not moving. But my mind was already racing. Emergency calls. That meant something was wrong. Owen never used emergency bypass unless it was actually urgent.

The phone buzzed again. Then again.

"Natalie," Brady said gently. "That sounds important."

I extracted myself from him, the loss of contact feeling sudden and cold, and walked naked to the dresser. Six missed calls from Owen. Three texts:

Natalie please call me

It's important

Are you okay? I'm getting worried

My heart rate, already elevated from sex, spiked higher. I called him back immediately, my hand shaking slightly.

He answered on the first ring. "Nat! Thank god. Are you okay?"

"I'm fine. What's wrong?"

"There was a shooting. Downtown, near your office. It just happened maybe twenty minutes ago. Some kind of workplace thing, I don't know the details, but it's all over the news and I couldn't reach you and I ..." His voice cracked. "I was terrified."

I could hear the genuine panic in his voice, the fear, and felt something cold settle in my stomach. Not guilt, still not quite guilt, but an awareness of what this looked like. What it would have meant if something had actually happened to me and I'd been unreachable because I was fucking someone in a hotel room.

"I'm okay," I said, making my voice calm, steady. "I'm not at the office. I had that dentist appointment, remember? I'm fine. I'm safe."

"The dentist. Right. Jesus, I forgot." He let out a shaky breath. "I'm sorry, I know I'm overreacting, but they're saying casualties and I just, "

"You're not overreacting. I should have told you when I left. I'm sorry I scared you."

Behind me, I could hear Brady moving around, probably getting dressed, giving me privacy for this conversation. I caught our reflection in the mirror, me standing there naked on the phone, him pulling on his jeans in the background, the rumpled bed between us. The image was so starkly wrong that I had to look away.

"When will you be back at the office?" Owen asked.

"I'm actually heading back now. The dentist finished early." Another lie, so smooth it barely registered. "I'll text you when I get there, okay?"

"Okay. I love you. I'm really glad you're safe."

"Love you too."

I hung up and stood there for a moment, phone in hand, trying to process what had just happened. A shooting. Downtown. Close enough to my office that Owen had panicked, had called me six times, had used emergency bypass because he thought I might be dead.

And I'd been here. Unreachable. Fucking Brady.

"Everything okay?" Brady asked quietly.

I turned to look at him. He was fully dressed now, leaning against the wall, watching me with concern that felt genuine but also intrusive. I was suddenly, acutely aware that I was still naked, that we'd just had sex, that he'd come inside me and I'd need to clean up before going back to my actual life.

"I need to get back to work," I said, not answering his question.

I went to the bathroom and closed the door. Used the toilet, cleaned myself up, stared at my reflection in the mirror. My makeup was smudged, my hair was a mess, my lips were swollen from kissing. I looked exactly like what I was.

I washed my face, reapplied makeup with hands that were steadier than they should have been, fixed my hair into something presentable. The wrap dress went back on, the lingerie adjusted beneath it. When I emerged, I looked like someone who'd been to the dentist, maybe. If you didn't look too closely.

Brady was sitting on the edge of the bed, phone in hand. "There's stuff all over Twitter about the shooting," he said. "It's bad. Like, really bad."

"I need to go," I said, gathering my purse, checking that I had everything.

He stood up. "When can I see you again?"

The question felt obscene in this moment, with people possibly dead or dying a few miles away, with Owen still probably shaking from panic in his lab.

"I don't know," I said honestly. "Work is intense right now. I'll text you."

"Natalie ... "

"I really need to go, Brady."

He looked like he wanted to say more, but something in my expression must have stopped him. He just nodded and picked up his gym bag.

We left the room together but separated in the lobby, him heading to the parking garage, me to my car on the street.

I sat in my car for a full minute before starting it, hands gripping the steering wheel, staring at nothing. My phone showed news alerts, five killed, shooter in custody, motive unclear. The address was three blocks from my office. Three blocks.

If I'd actually been at work. If I'd actually been where I was supposed to be.

I pushed the thought away and started the engine. Traffic was snarled, police barricades redirecting everything away from the affected area. It took me twenty minutes to navigate back to the office, and when I finally pulled into the garage, I saw Miranda standing outside the building on her phone, her face pale.

"Natalie!" She rushed over as I got out of the car. "Thank god. I've been trying to reach everyone. Are you okay?"

"I'm fine. I wasn't here. Dentist appointment."

"Right, right. Jesus." She ran a hand through her hair. "They've shut down the whole block. We can't get back inside. I'm sending everyone home for the day. Just... go home. Be with your people."

I nodded, and she pulled me into a brief, tight hug before hurrying off to coordinate with the rest of the team. I got back in my car and sat there, watching people mill around looking shaken, emergency vehicles still flashing in the distance.

My phone buzzed. Owen: *Any update? Can you get back to the office?*

Me: Building's closed. They're sending everyone home. I'm heading back to the apartment now

Owen: Thank god. I'm leaving the lab early. I'll meet you there

The drive home felt surreal. Every radio station was covering the shooting. Five dead, twelve injured. A former employee with a grudge. I changed the station to music, but even that felt wrong, too cheerful, too oblivious to what had just happened.

At the apartment, I let myself in and immediately went to shower. Really shower this time, washing away Brady thoroughly, his smell, his sweat, any trace of him. I scrubbed until my skin was pink, washed my hair twice, stood under the hot water until it started to run cold.

When I emerged, wrapped in a towel, Owen was in the living room. He must have come in while I was in the shower. He stood up the moment he saw me and crossed the room in three strides, pulling me into his arms.

"I was so scared," he said into my hair. "When I couldn't reach you, when I saw the news, I thought, "

"I'm okay," I said. "I'm right here."

He pulled back to look at me, his hands framing my face, and I saw something in his expression I couldn't quite read. Fear, yes. Relief, definitely. But something else underneath.

"Your phone went straight to voicemail," he said carefully. "All six times I called. Not even ringing, just straight to voicemail."

My stomach dropped. Do Not Disturb. I'd forgotten to turn it off.

"The dentist made me turn it off completely," I said without missing a beat. "Some new policy about electromagnetic interference with their equipment. I forgot to turn it back on after."

The lie was elaborate, specific, the kind of detail that made it believable. I watched Owen's face, saw him accept it, saw the suspicion, if that's what it was, dissolve into relief.

"God, that must have been so stressful," he said. "Coming out of the dentist to all those messages, not knowing what was happening."

"It was," I agreed, which was at least partially true.

He kissed me then, deep and desperate, like he was confirming I was really there, really solid, really alive. I kissed him back with matching intensity, and felt him respond, his hands tightening on my waist.

"I need you," he said against my mouth. "Right now. Is that okay?"

I nodded, and he walked me backward to the bedroom, urgent in a way he rarely was. The towel fell away, and he pushed me onto the bed, already working at his belt, his shirt.

We had sex with an intensity that felt different from usual, raw, almost frantic. Owen held me tighter, moved harder, made sounds that suggested he was working through something emotional rather than just physical. When he came, he buried his face in my neck and I felt wetness that might have been sweat or might have been tears.

Afterward, he held me close, his heartbeat gradually slowing against my back.

"I can't lose you," he said quietly. "I know that's dramatic, I know nothing actually happened to you today, but when I thought maybe, " He couldn't finish the sentence.

"You're not going to lose me," I said, the words automatic.

We lay there in the dimming afternoon light, and I stared at the wall, feeling the weight of the day settling over me. I'd had sex with two different men in the span of three hours. Had lied to both of them, in different ways, for different reasons. Had narrowly avoided catastrophe only because of random chance, a shooting that had nothing to do with me but had almost exposed everything.

I should have felt something. Fear, maybe. A wake-up call. Some sense that I was playing with fire and eventually I'd get burned.

Instead, I felt a strange calm. Like I'd passed a test. Like the universe had thrown something at me and I'd navigated it successfully, maintained all the separate realities, kept all the plates spinning.

My phone buzzed on the nightstand. I reached for it carefully, not disturbing Owen.

Brady: *Just saw the news. Holy shit. Are you okay?*

I deleted the message without responding and set the phone back down.

Owen's breathing had evened out into sleep, the crash after adrenaline, probably. I extracted myself carefully and went to the bathroom, closing the door before turning on the light.

In the mirror, I looked the same as I always did. Same face, same body, same everything. Nothing visible to indicate what I'd done, who I'd been with, what kind of person I actually was.

I thought about the five people who'd died today. Thought about their families finding out, their worlds ending in an instant. Thought about

Owen's panic when he couldn't reach me.

And I felt nothing. Not relief that I was alive, not gratitude that I'd been somewhere else, not even guilt that my alibi had been another man's bed.

Just a distant, clinical observation: that was close.

I went back to the bedroom. Owen had rolled onto his side, one arm stretched across my pillow. I slid back under the covers and he immediately pulled me close, even in sleep, like his body was programmed to reach for me.

The next few days blurred together. The office remained closed while police investigated, which gave me unexpected time at home. Owen worked from the apartment, grateful to have me nearby, still shaken from his scare. We cooked together, watched movies, had sex with a frequency and intensity that suggested he was still processing his fear of losing me.

I played the part perfectly. Attentive girlfriend, grateful to be alive, appropriately sobered by the tragedy. I even went with Owen to a vigil for the victims, standing in a crowd of strangers holding candles, listening to people talk about senseless violence and cherishing every moment.

Brady texted twice. I responded minimally, citing work stress and needing space. By Friday, he'd stopped trying.

The following Tuesday, the office reopened. Miranda called an all-hands meeting, brought in grief counselors, talked about resilience and community. The Peterson pitch had been pushed back two weeks out of respect for everything that had happened.

That afternoon, I told Miranda I needed to run a personal errand. She waved me off without question, everyone was being given grace in the aftermath.

I drove to a different part of town, to a climbing gym I'd never been to before. Paid for a day pass. Changed into my climbing clothes in the locker room and studied my reflection. The athletic version of myself, the one who'd given me the cover story that had made everything possible.

I should have been thinking about quitting. About how close I'd come to disaster, how easily it all could have fallen apart. About Owen's face when he'd finally reached me, the genuine terror in his voice.

Instead, I was scanning the gym, observing the instructors, noting which ones were attractive, which ones seemed confident, which ones wore wedding rings and which ones didn't.

A guy spotted me from across the gym, mid-twenties, muscular, with that easy charm of someone used to being looked at. He came over while I was chalking my hands.

"First time here?" he asked.

"Yeah. Just trying out different gyms. Seeing what I like."

"Well, if you need any pointers, I'm Adam. I teach the intermediate classes."

"Natalie," I said, meeting his eyes and holding them just long enough to be meaningful. "I might take you up on that."

His smile widened. "I hope you do."

I watched him walk away, appreciating the view, already calculating. Adam. Tuesday and Thursday afternoons, probably. Different gym, different person, different set of logistics to navigate. Brady was getting too attached anyway, too needy, too close to becoming complicated.

Better to start fresh.

My phone buzzed. Owen: *Dinner at my parents' tonight, forgot to mention. That okay? We can cancel if you're not up for it*

Me: *No, that's fine. What time?*

Owen: *6:30. Love you*

Me: *Love you too*

I put my phone in my locker and approached the climbing wall. I Started an easy route, feeling my muscles engage, the familiar focus that came with problem-solving the physical challenge. I'd gotten good at this, good enough that the lie had become partially true. I actually enjoyed climbing now, actually looked forward to the workout, the meditation of it.

That was the thing about good lies. The best ones were built on foundations of truth.

Adam watched me from across the gym. I could feel his attention like a physical thing, could sense his interest. When I finished the route and jumped down, he was there with a water bottle.

"Nice technique," he said. "You've been climbing a while."

"Six months or so. Still learning."

"You're a natural." He paused, then said, "I'm teaching a private session tomorrow afternoon if you want to join. One-on-one coaching. Really helps with advancing to the next level."

"What time?"

"Two o'clock work for you?"

I mentally reviewed my schedule. The office would still be in reduced capacity. Miranda wouldn't question another afternoon away. Owen was back at the lab full-time, deep in his research, trusting as ever.

"Two o'clock works perfectly," I said.

Adam's smile suggested he understood exactly what kind of session this would be. "Great. I'll put you down. Looking forward to it, Natalie."

"Me too."

I finished my workout and drove home as the sun began its descent. The city looked the same as always, people in their cars, heading to wherever they were supposed to be, living their ordinary lives. No one looking at me would see anything unusual. Just a woman driving home from the gym, probably thinking about dinner, about her evening, about normal things.

At the apartment, I let myself in and started preparing for dinner at Owen's parents'. I changed into an appropriate outfit, a navy dress that his mother would approve of, not that I needed to pass her judgement, simple jewelry, minimal makeup. When Owen got home, I was ready, perfect, exactly what he needed me to be.

"You look beautiful," he said, kissing me at the door.

"Thank you. Should we bring wine?"

"Already got some in the car. Red, the kind Dad likes."

We drove to his parents' house holding hands, and I listened to him talk about his day, his research, his hopes for the funding decision. At dinner, I deked and charmed his mother, discussed literature with his father, played the role of ideal girlfriend to Owen, destined to become ideal wife, probably is what they were all thinking.

And tomorrow afternoon, I'd meet Adam for our "private session," wouldn't I.

Because this was who I was. Not the good girlfriend, not the professional marketer, not any single version of anything. But all of them at once, and none of them completely, moving through the world, taking what I wanted, building elaborate architectures of deception, and feeling nothing but satisfied with my own capacity for compartmentalization. I carried it off like a job, like a career.

If the shooting hadn't changed me, nothing would change me. I was magnificent and monstrous, I was such a bad girlfriend, and I was just only going to get worse.